

Chennai Confidential

A pen that slices amid sizzling heat and fetid odours



BUSHRA HASAN

| By Geeta Doctor |



FIRST LOVE
by BRINDA CHARRY
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 211

The sense of once small tight worlds under attack is just one of the themes that recurs in this collection of short stories. Though they range far and wide from the snow drifts of outer Boston to the heat and languor of small towns of south India, they are branded with a certain sameness. They carry with them the sweet-sour taste of green mangoes sliced and indented like yellow dentures dipped in chilli powder, a staple of hot summer evenings on the sandy beaches of Chennai. It's a flavour that could be called TamBrahm. It suggests a twitchy nose for smells, a need to define the invisible barriers between different people, an overwhelming desire to document and describe the exhalations of the body in heat.

That perhaps is what gives Brinda Charry her bite. She wriggles her blade under the skin of her characters and watches them squirm. It's not entirely accidental that one thinks of teeth. It's one of the recurring images she offers: the viciously inclined brother who has a brilliant smile, the toothless gape of the grandfather who once followed an enchanting female spirit into the rice fields of the family estate. Or in the title story itself. In *First Love*, Charry evokes the difference that a new family coming into the locality creates: "They are secretive too. They raised the walls before they came to live here and embedded them with sharp-edged glass chips which glisten like multi-coloured teeth in the sun." This image has been enlarged and air-brushed to look as seductive as a shampoo ad for the cover. It suggests the saccharine qualities one associates with the fiction-writing in women's magazines of a certain kind.

It's precisely what Charry is not attempting to do. She might well be reclaiming moments of her past and pinning the butterfly wings of memory onto the soft boards of her North American life. She turns her modern day fairy-tales inside out like another Angela Carter, the late British feminist writer whose *Company of Wolves* revelled in the sub-texts of Little Red Riding Hood's carnal desires and rewrites them as much for herself as for the reader. They crawl and shimmer in the heat of an Indian summer filled with the sting of repressed desires. If this is love, she seems to suggest it should be called: In the company of wasps. ■

Chic Thrills

An expat wife finds art and espionage in trendy Mumbai

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

A socialite thriller with diamond-dripping and Birkin-bearing ladies of leisure whose job description it is to exercise. A travelogue through Mumbai's innards where NRIs come back to live the emerging markets dream. A mommy monologue that spans all the gripes of young newly non-working mothers, from getting junior into the right school to hiring the perfect nanny to finding just the most darling Pucci print kurtis. *Faking It* is all this and more, written in a style that easily mixes high art espionage with low rent supermarket romance. It's about a Desi Clueless Back from America who comes to India with her hedge fund husband and proceeds to buy an apparently undiscovered Amrita Sher-Gil which turns out to be a fake.

How she uncovers the plot, falls in love with her husband again and learns to adore Mumbai, its bejewelled Madonnas and sprawling slums is the story. Chick lit usually suffers from a lack of a lived life but Amrita Chowdhury is clearly a trooper who's been around the world. Her observations about expat life in Mumbai are self-mocking—she speaks of her driver's rank armpit smell and blames it on her husband who has dragged her halfway across the world, forcing her to live in the lap of luxury. And her writing oozes intelligence—she writes of how two glamazons of uncertain age have enough kohl between them to make a five by five foot charcoal sketch. All right, so it's a trifle. But hey, it's a delicious one. ■



FAKING IT
by AMRITA CHOWDHURY
Hachette India
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 338